The electric current in a conductor is defined as the rate of flow of charges through a given cross-sectional area A. It is shown in the Figure 2.2.

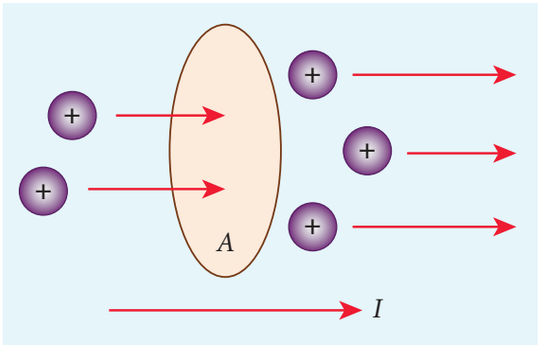


Figure 2.2 Charges flow across the area A

If a net charge Q passes through any cross section of a conductor in time t, then the current is defined as $I = \frac{Q}{t}$**.** But charge flow is not always constant. Hence current can more generally be defined as

$$I_{avg} = \frac{\Delta Q}{\Delta t} \qquad (2.1)$$

Where ΔQ is the amount of charge that passes through the conductor at any cross section during the time interval Δt. If the rate at which charge flows changes in time, the current also changes. The instantaneous current I is defined as the limit of the average current, as $\Delta t \to 0$

$$I = \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \frac{\Delta Q}{\Delta t} = \frac{dQ}{dt} \qquad (2.2)$$

The SI unit of current is the **ampere** (A)

$$1A = \frac{1C}{1s}$$

That is, 1A of current is equivalent to 1 Coulomb of charge passing through a perpendicular cross section in 1second. The electric current is a scalar quantity.

EXAMPLE 2.1

Compute the current in the wire if a charge of 120 C is flowing through a copper wire in 1 minute.

Solution

The current (rate of flow of charge) in the wire is

$$I = \frac{Q}{t} = \frac{120}{60} = 2A$$

2.1.1 Conventional Current

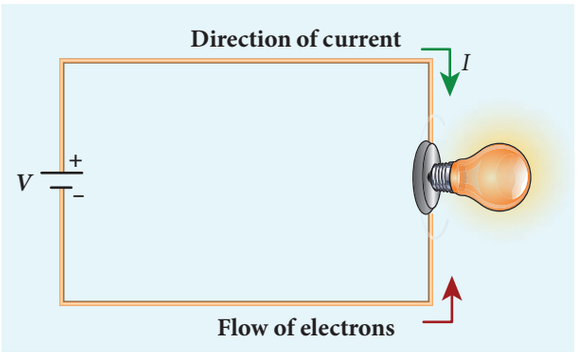


Figure 2.3 Direction of conventional current and electron flow

In an electric circuit, arrow heads are used to indicate the direction of flow of current. By convention, this flow in the circuit should be from the positive terminal of the battery to the negative terminal. This current is called the conventional current or simply current and is in the direction in which a positive test charge would move. In typical circuits the charges that flow are actually electrons, from the negative terminal of the battery to the positive. As a result, the flow of electrons and the direction of conventional current points in opposite direction as shown in Figure 2.3. Mathematically, a transfer of positive charge

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